

7 Links

The most important components of a web page are undoubtedly its links. It is very rare that a web page doesn't link to another. A Google results page is all about links. Creating a link isn't difficult, but managing to link to another web page is only the beginning. With CSS, links can be made both beautiful and functional. From rollover colours to advanced image maps and complex menus, link styling is a vast and evolving area of web design.

Whenever you create a link you have to consider the end user, but a link has a very important role to play, and its basic functionality should never be compromised in pursuit of enhancement. There are a million things you can do with links to enhance the user's experience. Let us check out how this can be done.

7.1 Link markup

The link is a very simple concept, whether you are using text or an image it's one of the first bits of code that most of us get to know when dealing with HTML. The basic markup for a text link is as follows:

```
<a href="http://www.google.com">Google</a>
```

Or to use an image as the link and ensuring that the alt attribute is used to provide relevant link text should the image not be available:

```
<a href="http://www.google.com"></a>
```

Other attributes are also available, such as title, used to provide a tool tip for additional information when the user hovers over the link:

```
<a href="http://www.google.com" title="Visit the best search engine in the world">Google</a>
```

This markup is all that is needed to hook up CSS rules for styling the links. Naturally, as links are self-contained elements, they can be combined with parent elements such as lists, or housed in custom containers in order for more specific descendant selectors to take effect and treat links in different ways depending upon where they sit in the page.

7.2 Default link styling

By default, browsers have a set CSS for links. If you have ever worked with a link without applied CSS you will be aware that the default browser style sheet will render unvisited links in dark blue, visited links in purple, and so on, and that these links will be underlined. This convention is a staple